In this edict, after a traditional Buddhist greeting the king offered advice on religious expositions. Even while acknowledging that what the Buddha had spoken was well spoken, he made it clear that he desired ‘many groups of monks and (many) nuns’ to repeatedly listen to and reflect on particular dhammic expositions.[53] The expositions were several and specific: the epigraph mentions *Vinaya-samukasa*, the *Aliya-vasas*, the *Anagata-bhayas*, the *Muni-gathas*, the *Moneya-suta*, the *Upatisa-pasina*, and the *Laghulovada*. There is no clarity about the exact canonical writings to which he alludes because what is recognizable today as part of the Buddhist canon is not in the form in which it figures in this epigraph. Scholars of Buddhism, though, maintain that such expositions were likely to contain all kinds of advice on how ‘to conform to their discipline, be content with their lot, overcome their temptations, delight in solitude, enclose themselves in wise silence’, and so on.[54] What seems remarkable is the confidence with which the emperor gives this advice to the Buddhist community: it is as though he sees himself as the Buddha’s preacher-successor.

Much was also built for the Buddhist community of Bairat. Most unusual and impressive is a temple for the community on a platform on the hilltop where his advice is inscribed. This was in the form of a circular chamber with a circumabulatory passage, in turn surrounded by an encircling wall. The wall of the inner shrine was made of panels of brickwork alternating with twenty-six wooden columns.[55] The circumambulatory passage was covered by an inclined roof supported on one side by the outer brick wall and on the inner side by the wooden architraves of the pillars of the central shrine. Interestingly, the outer wall of the temple had Mauryan Brahmi on it: several bricks inscribed with one or two characters were found built into the wall. Daya Ram Sahni, the excavator, read a few (‘pasam, visa, vi, kama’) and considered the possibility that they could have been ‘extracts from the very texts from the Buddhist scripture, which in the Bairat-Calcutta edict, Ashoka had exhorted his subjects to listen to and study for